Leave Policy

Kestrel Pay Ltd. Owner: Marco Bianchi, Head of People. Maintained by Rachel Obi, HR Business Partner. Version 2026.1, effective 1 January 2026, last updated 2 March 2026.

This policy covers annual leave, sickness absence, family leave and other time off for employees in London, Lisbon and Dublin. Where local law gives you more, local law applies. Contractors follow their contract.

1. Annual leave

1.1 Entitlement

The leave year runs from 1 January to 31 December.

Office	Annual leave	Public holidays	Winter closure
London	27 days	England bank holidays (8 in 2026)	3 days
Lisbon	25 days	Portuguese national holidays, the Lisbon municipal holiday, and Carnaval	3 days
Dublin	25 days	Irish public holidays (10 in 2026)	3 days

You get one extra day of annual leave after 3 years' service and a second after 5 years, to a maximum of 2 extra days. Part-time employees get the same entitlement pro rata. If you join or leave during the year, your entitlement is pro rata to the days you work in that year, rounded up to the nearest half day.

1.2 Booking leave

- Book leave in Kestrel People. Your manager approves it.
- Give notice of at least twice the length of the leave: 2 weeks' notice for a week off, for example. For a single day, 2 working days is enough.
- More than 10 working days in a row needs your head of department's approval as well.
- Managers can decline leave in busy periods; these are listed in the Holiday Calendar for the year.

1.3 Carrying leave over

You can carry up to 5 days of unused leave into the next year. Carried-over days must be used by 31 March, or they are lost. If you could not take leave because of sickness or family leave, you can carry over all the leave you missed, and you have 18 months to use it.

1.4 Buying leave (UK only)

You can buy up to 5 extra days a year through salary sacrifice. Apply in the November window for the next leave year. The cost is spread over the 12 monthly salaries.

2. Sickness absence

- Tell your manager by 10:00 on your first day of absence, by phone or Teams message, and record the absence in Kestrel People. Your manager does not need to know details you prefer to keep private.
- For absences of 7 calendar days or fewer you do not need a doctor's note. After that, provide a fit note (UK) or local equivalent.
- After probation, company sick pay is 10 working days at full pay in any rolling 12 months. After that, statutory or local sick pay applies.
- After an absence of more than 2 weeks, your manager will hold a return-to-work conversation with you to agree any changes that would help.

3. Family leave

Leave	Company pay	Eligibility
Maternity or primary adopter leave	26 weeks at full pay, then statutory pay	From day one
Partner or secondary adopter leave	6 weeks at full pay, taken in the first 12 months	From day one
Shared parental leave (UK)	Matched to the maternity pay above, shared between parents	From day one
Fertility treatment appointments	Up to 5 days a year at full pay	From day one
Dependants leave (emergencies)	Up to 3 days a year at full pay	From day one

In Portugal and Ireland, statutory leave and benefits apply, and Kestrel tops up your pay to match the full-pay weeks in the table. Tell the People team at least 15 weeks before the expected due date or placement date, or as soon as you can.

4. Other time off

Type	Paid days	Notes
Compassionate leave, close family	Up to 5 days	Partner, child, parent, sibling. Talk to your manager if you need more.
Compassionate leave, others	Up to 2 days	Grandparents, in-laws, close friends
Volunteering	2 days a year	For a registered charity, booked like annual leave
Moving house	1 day a year	
Jury service and public duties	Full pay for up to 10 days	Tell your manager as soon as you are summoned
Unpaid leave	Up to 4 weeks	Head of department approval

5. Time off in lieu

Time off in lieu is only given where a policy or rota says so, for example on-call call-outs or working on a winter closure day. It must be agreed with your manager and taken within 4 weeks, except for winter closure days, which must be taken by 31 March.

6. Leaving

If you leave, untaken leave for the year is paid with your final salary. If you have taken more leave than you have earned, the difference is deducted.

7. Contacts

- Questions about this policy: Rachel Obi, HR Business Partner
- Exceptions: Marco Bianchi, Head of People